and displayed a penchant for excessive caution. ‘When there was a very difficult decision to make, he always wanted to push it forward with the hope that may be a better decision would be available in the future,’ the dean explained.

In addition, Mistry blamed Ratan for poor decisions and most disturbingly, for interfering with the working of the group. He was looking for a scapegoat for his failures, remarks Nohria. In the first year of Mistry’s appointment, news had begun to reach Ratan that his successor was spreading canards that he was interfering in the policies that Mistry was trying to implement, blunting the effectiveness of his initiatives.

Nohria says that, on the contrary, after he had handed over the reins to Mistry, Ratan ‘had stepped off of everything and was out of the whole picture’. Brushing aside stories of his interference, Ratan initially dealt with them internally and away from the public gaze. Ratan says that he thought these must be the handiwork of disgruntled elements. They could also have been looking for ways to render Mistry less powerful by creating a divide between Tata Sons and Tata Trusts, he concluded.

But more stories of Mistry blaming Ratan continued to circulate. The fact that many of these stories were emanating from myriad and unconnected sources lent credence to their authenticity. Schacht of Cummins Diesel and later CEO of Lucent Technologies, says that he informed Ratan that he had heard that Mistry’s inner circle was spreading rumours that Ratan was stifling the new chairman’s performance.

Around the middle of 2013, Nohria divulged to Ratan that the ‘confidants of Cyrus were spreading stories that he had no freedom to function’. He added that the rumours going around were that the former chairman was preventing Cyrus from being his own man.

Soon, other events, together with the news shared by Schacht and Nohria, pointed to the high probability of Mistry’s inner circle being the source of such stories. This looked plausible when Corus’s fortunes turned for the worse and Mistry took no visible steps to shore up the company’s prospects. Instead, stories circulated that Corus was acquired at an exorbitant price, disregarding the fact that Tata Steel had quoted only 5 pence a share more than CSN, its competitor, in the keenly fought bidding.

Mistry’s refrain was that he was saddled with the legacy ‘hot spots’ left behind by Ratan. The reality was that most of the criticisms of a section of the analysts that the cost for Corus was high was mostly ‘with the benefit of